

12 takeaways from von der Leyen's State of the Union

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By Sebastian Starcevic · Sep 16, 2026, 1:19 PM · [View in your browser](#)

Ursula von der Leyen used her State of the Union speech to unveil a raft of proposals aimed at making Europe better prepared for a world of threats — from sweltering summers to hybrid warfare, migrant crises and even TikTok.

What the Commission president chose to talk about in Strasbourg — and, just as importantly, what she left unsaid — will help define the rest of her term and the political legacy she leaves behind.

Here are the 12 biggest takeaways.

1. Canada could become the EU's first "associate member"

The biggest surprise came when von der Leyen said she wanted to open the door for Canada to become the EU's first "associate member."

Speaking directly to Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, who was sitting in the Parliament hemicycle, von der Leyen proposed an ambitious, far-reaching new alliance spanning tech, defense, energy, critical minerals, AI, the Arctic and more.

In a message that could have been addressed directly to U.S. President Donald Trump, von der Leyen said: "This is not a partnership against anyone else, but for our common strength."

While it remains to be seen whether EU member countries are on board with so-called associate membership — a model, it should be noted, that does not currently exist — the proposal is a striking signal of how badly Brussels wants to deepen ties with Ottawa.

2. Europe might finally get a security council

The idea of a European security executive body has been floated in various forms for years, but has taken on fresh urgency against the backdrop of Trump undermining the transatlantic security relationship and Russia's war against Ukraine spilling over into the bloc.

Von der Leyen injected new life into the discussion by calling to create a European Security Council, saying it would bring together the EU and like-minded countries, including the United Kingdom, Canada, Ukraine and Norway (notably, there was no mention of the U.S.) to discuss and manage threats.

It would go hand-in-hand with a new “Emergency Security Protocol,” which EU countries could trigger in response to threats short of an actual attack or invasion. “In other words, a mechanism to flank NATO’s Article 4,” she said.

3. EU wants to work together on AI, but not with the U.S. or China

The Commission president is inviting the major AI labs to Brussels to discuss efforts to “pace the frontier” of AI development.

“AI comes with a balance of possibilities and risks,” she said. “Without addressing these risks, we will never be able to unlock AI’s possibilities.”

Von der Leyen called for cooperation with the United Kingdom, Canada “and others” on AI but did not mention the U.S. or China — the two countries leading the global AI race.

4. Unused SAFE money is heading to Ukraine

There is now an answer to what happens to the money left over from the EU’s €150 billion SAFE defense-loan program.

Von der Leyen said the remaining funds would be used for a new program involving joint projects with Ukrainian defense companies.

The announcement potentially turns an administrative problem — member countries such as Italy not taking up all the cheap loans available to them — into a way to integrate Ukraine’s battlefield expertise and defense industry with Europe’s.

5. Climate policy is becoming more about survival

Von der Leyen’s climate message was notably focused on preparing for the worst rather than new emissions-cutting measures.

She defended the EU’s existing climate targets but devoted much of her attention to dealing with the consequences of a hotter Europe, including a forthcoming European Heatwave Plan, a European Water Initiative and a Climate Insurance Alliance.

She said there can be “no repeat of this summer,” which was Europe’s hottest ever, causing its forests to burn and its rivers to dry up.

6. Von der Leyen wants to stop “gold-plating”

The Commission president wants EU countries to agree on a new “pact against gold-plating” — the practice of adding national requirements when implementing EU legislation.

“We are doing our best at the European level to cut red tape. But now I think it is time for the member states to step up,” she said.

While von der Leyen called for the overhaul of the single market to be completed by the end of 2027, she otherwise glossed over simplification and competitiveness in her speech.

7. Admitting defeat on Israel

Von der Leyen acknowledged the “deep suffering” in Gaza and condemned “unchecked settler violence” in the West Bank, while saying Europe must keep the two-state solution alive.

But she also openly acknowledged the EU’s inability to agree on some of the measures she promised last year, with member countries unable to agree on action.

The failure to secure majorities for sanctions against Israeli settlers and ministers, she said, was “painful for many Europeans.”

“When Europe is divided, it cannot change the course of events,” she added.

8. Surprisingly little to say about finance

For a Commission that has spent much of the past year talking about making Europe a more attractive place to invest and scale up, financial policy was largely absent from the address.

Von der Leyen’s main new financial announcement was a Banking Package focused on simplification and tackling fragmentation — a proposal the Commission had already announced in July.

There was little new on the broader ambition to turn Europe into a major investment hub.

9. Not giving up on a big EU budget

Von der Leyen put pressure on national governments to approve new EU-wide taxes to finance the bloc’s next seven-year budget.

“To be very clear, our budget is about our future. And any modern budget needs new own resources,” she said, referring to the term for EU taxes.

The Commission’s proposal to generate over €60 billion through new levies has been met with resistance in national capitals.

10. China got an ominous mention

One of the questions looming over the speech was how hard von der Leyen would go in on China.

On Wednesday, she slammed the EU’s trade deficit with Beijing — “one billion a day. It has reached a tipping point,” she said — and highlighted “dangerous dependencies” on China for critical raw materials.

But on trade, she stopped short of calling for any dramatic measures — something she did in her 2023 speech — when she launched an anti-subsidy investigation into electric vehicles. “We will use all the tools at our disposal to rebalance our relationship,” she said this year, in an apparent reference to the EU’s still-under-construction diversification instrument, but did not go further.

11. Getting tough on migration

In the wake of the Ceuta crisis, von der Leyen called for a European Emergency Response Framework, which would give EU countries in similar scenarios “time-limited and strictly defined flexibility in standard procedures.” Translation: returning migrants faster without worrying about granting asylum.

She also wants the bloc to strengthen Frontex, its border agency, but did not mention raising staff numbers, as she has called for previously.

12. Banning kids from TikTok

Von der Leyen took aim at social media, which she said was stealing childhoods, and vowed tougher action to protect kids online, including keeping some minors off popular platforms like TikTok and Instagram.

“No social media under the age of 13. No personal account under the age of 15,” she said, adding platforms would also have to introduce “safe design” for under-18s.

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